# Infant Mortality in Wisconsin

## Evidence, Equity, and Policy

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# Overview

1. Wisconsin has among the worst Black–White infant mortality disparities in the U.S.
2. Evidence-based interventions can achieve meaningful reductions
3. Milwaukee is the only county-level setting where effects are detectable
4. The Birth Equity Act proposes seven bills aligned with the evidence

# The Disparity

- In 2023, Wisconsin's Black infant mortality rate was **14.3 per 1,000** compared with **4.4 for White infants** — a more than threefold gap
- Wisconsin has had one of the worst Black infant mortality rates among U.S. states (Tomlin et al., 2021)
- Nationally, Black infant mortality is about twice the White rate; Wisconsin's gap is worse (KFF, 2025)

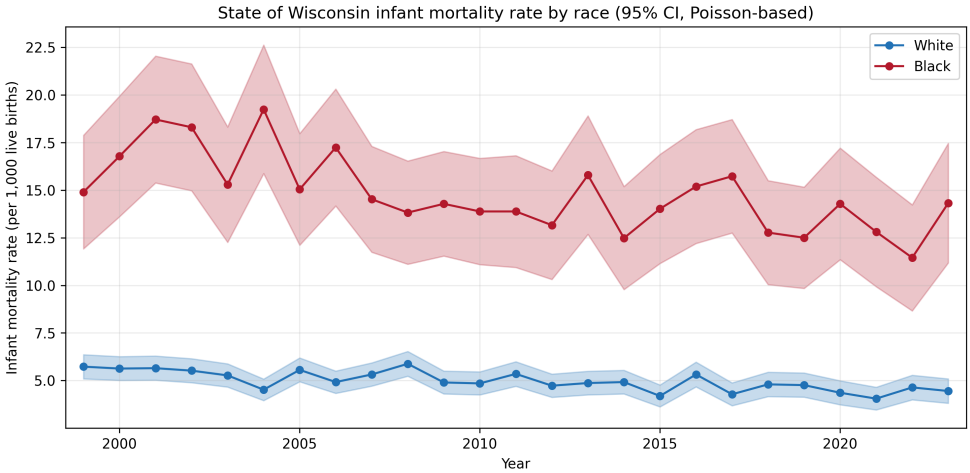
**Drivers:** higher rates of premature birth among Black infants *and* higher mortality among term Black infants (SIDS, accidents, assaults)

# Rates by Geography and Race (2019–2023)

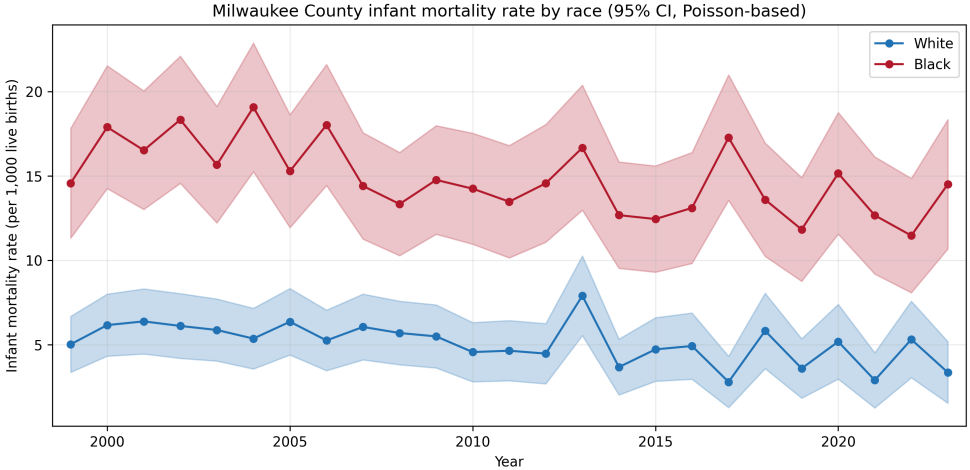
| Geography | Race | Rate | 95% CI | Deaths/yr |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| State | White | 4.45 | 3.8–5.1 | 192 |
| State | Black | 13.07 | 10.1–15.9 | 79 |
| Milwaukee | White | 4.05 | 2.2–6.1 | 17 |
| Milwaukee | Black | 13.12 | 9.7–16.6 | 55 |
| Dane | White | 3.47 | 1.7–5.4 | 14 |
| Dane | Black | 11.24 | 2.4–21.7 | 6 |
| Rest of WI | White | 4.61 | 3.9–5.3 | 162 |
| Rest of WI | Black | 13.56 | 7.5–19.9 | 19 |

Black infant mortality is about three times White in every geography.

# State of Wisconsin: Rates Over Time



# Milwaukee County: Rates Over Time




Milwaukee has ~4,190 Black births and ~55 Black infant deaths per year — the largest concentration in Wisconsin.

# Dane County and Rest of Wisconsin

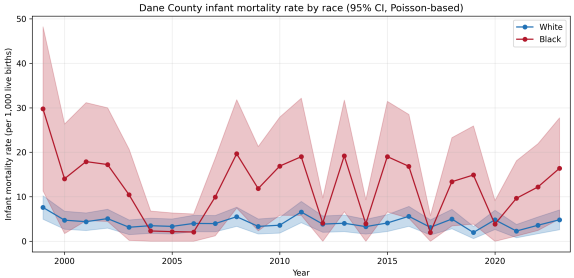



Figure 1: Dane County

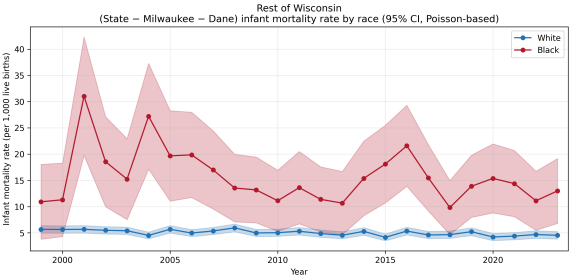



Figure 2: Rest of Wisconsin

Wide confidence intervals reflect small numbers of Black infant deaths outside Milwaukee.

# Evidence: What Reduces Infant Mortality?

| Intervention | Effect | Cost |
|---|---|---|
| Nurse-Family Partnership | ~500 deaths (projected U.S.) | ~0.31 lives/$1M |
| Denmark SIDS campaign | 17.2% reduction | Not reported |
| Immediate KMC | 58 in trial; ~150k/yr scale | Low (LMICs) |
| Back to Sleep (U.S.) | >50% SIDS decline | Not attributed |
| KMC (meta-analysis) | ~32% (RR 0.68) | Low (LMICs) |

NFP is the only intervention with a clear cost-effectiveness estimate: ~$3.2M per infant death averted (Miller, 2015; Olds et al., 2014).

# Why Milwaukee?

Milwaukee is the only county-level geography where a 32% rate reduction would be detectable in one year of data.

| Geography | Race | Margin | 32% red. | Detectable? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| State | Black | 2.97 | 4.18 | Yes |
| Milwaukee | Black | 3.42 | 4.20 | Yes |
| Dane | Black | 8.84 | 3.60 | No |
| Rest of WI | Black | 6.06 | 4.34 | No |

At NFP rates, averting the minimum detectable number of Milwaukee Black infant deaths (15) would cost ~$48M/year.

# The Birth Equity Act

State Rep. Shelia Stubbs has introduced seven bills (AB 1082–1088) to address Wisconsin's Black infant and maternal mortality (Cap Times, 2026):

| Bill | Description | Evidence |
|---|---|---|
| AB 1082 | Breastfeeding equipment tax exemption | Indirect |
| AB 1083 | No recovery of birth expenses | Indirect |
| AB 1084 | Medicaid dental in pregnancy | Limited |
| AB 1085 | Medicaid doula coverage | By analogy |
| AB 1086 | Maternal mental health screening | Indirect |
| AB 1087 | Special enrollment for pregnancy | Indirect |
| AB 1088 | Postpartum home visit | Direct |

# Key Takeaways

1. Wisconsin's Black–White infant mortality gap is about **3:1** in every geography
2. Milwaukee has the **largest number** of Black infant deaths (~55/year) and is the **best-powered setting** for evaluation
3. Evidence-based interventions (home visiting, safe sleep) can achieve **17–32% reductions**
4. The **Birth Equity Act** aligns with the evidence; AB 1088 (postpartum home visit) has the strongest link
5. Concentrating **implementation and evaluation in Milwaukee** maximizes the chance of learning what works

# Scope and Limitations

- This analysis examines all-cause infant mortality only; cause-specific analysis (neonatal vs. postneonatal, SIDS, injuries) is recommended for future work
- Poisson CIs assume independence of deaths
- WISH data use Non-Hispanic White and Non-Hispanic Black only
- Suppressed Black death counts imputed as Total − White

# References


Cap Times. (2026). Wisconsin's black babies, moms die at "shameful" rates, lawmaker says. *Cap Times*.

KFF. (2025). *Racial disparities in maternal and infant health: Current status and key issues*.

Miller, T. R. (2015). Projected outcomes of nurse-family partnership home visitation during 1996–2013, united states. *Prevention Science*, *16*(6), 765–777.

Olds, D. L., Kitzman, H., Knudtson, M. D., Anson, E., Smith, J. A., & Cole, R. (2014). Effect of home visiting by nurses on maternal and child mortality: Results of a 2-decade follow-up of a randomized clinical trial. *JAMA Pediatrics*, *168*(9), 800–806.

Tomlin, B. D., McAdams, R. M., Zapata, J. Y., & Kaluarachchi, D. C. (2021). High black infant mortality in wisconsin: Factors associated with the ongoing racial inequity. *Journal of Perinatology*, *41*, 212–219.